PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

# Jeep Wrangler JK Unlimited

2007–2018 · JK Unlimited · JKU

BOXYTRUCKS

## CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Pick your engine first**
  2007–2011 trucks have the 3.8 and four-speed automatic; 2012–2018 have the Pentastar and five-speed. Driving Line suggests 2013 or later for a daily driver and says any year is fine for a weekend trail rig.
- [ ] **Drive it over a pothole at 50 mph**
  Death wobble usually shows up at 45–65 mph after a bump. Have someone turn the wheel a quarter turn each way with the engine running while you watch both ends of the front track bar. Any movement at the bushing or bracket is a red flag.
- [ ] **Look at the oil filter housing**
  On a 3.6, pull the engine cover and look for oil in the valley at the back of the engine, and for oil on the bellhousing. The plastic housing is a known leaker. Curbside Classic's 2015 JK started leaking at about 55,000 miles.
- [ ] **On a 3.8, check for oil burning and manifold ticks**
  Ask how much oil it uses between changes, and listen for a cold-start exhaust tick, which can mean a cracked manifold. Driving Line also lists intake-gasket failures and, on hard-used engines, ring and main-bearing failures from about 100,000 miles.
- [ ] **2012–2013: ask about the left cylinder head**
  Chrysler extended the warranty on the left cylinder head of affected 2012–2013 Wrangler Pentastars (2011–2013 across its range) to 10 years or 150,000 miles; its bulletin covers excessive cylinder leakage showing up as misfire codes. Ask whether the head has been replaced and get the dealer record.
- [ ] **Sight down the front axle**
  On lifted trucks with big tires, look for bent axle tubes or C-ends and uneven tire wear. Check for a truss. A bent Dana 30 housing usually means replacing it, often with a Dynatrac or Currie unit.
- [ ] **Weigh the build against the door sticker**
  Bumpers, a winch, a rack and a tent can put a JKU over its payload before anyone gets in. Check the sticker, and look at the rear coils and the bump-stop gap for sag.
- [ ] **Modified Jeeps: price the parts, then get a shop inspection**
  Driving Line's advice is to research every listed aftermarket part, have a 4×4 shop inspect the truck, and assume a heavily built Jeep has had a hard life.

## YEARS TO KNOW

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| **2007** | BEWARE | JK launch (production from August 2006): 3.8 EGH V6 (202 hp) with a 6-speed manual or 4-speed 42RLE auto; Rubicon has Dana 44s with lockers, 4:1 Rock-Trac and a sway-bar disconnect; the four-door Unlimited is new. First-year trucks drew several recalls |

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| | | (SlashGear), 2007–08 log the most complaints on CarComplaints.com (CarGurus), and Driving Line warns the 3.8 burns oil, leaks intake gaskets and cracks exhaust manifolds |
| **2012** | SWEET SPOT | 3.6 Pentastar V6 (285 hp, 260 lb-ft) and 5-speed W5A580 automatic replace the 3.8 and the 4-speed. The Pentastar is the engine to have (Quadratec, Driving Line); Driving Line's daily-driver pick is a 2013 or newer |

## RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Driver airbag clockspring**
  2007–2010 · NHTSA 16V-290
- ☐ **Takata passenger airbag inflator**
  2007–2012 · NHTSA 16V-352
- ☐ **Takata passenger inflator (Zone A states)**
  2009–2013 · NHTSA 18V-021
- ☐ **Driver airbag inflator**
  2010–2016 · NHTSA 19V-018
- ☐ **Automatic transmission overheat warning**
  2007–2008 · NHTSA 09V-436
- ☐ **Front brake lines vs inner fender liner**
  2007–2010 · NHTSA 10V-236
- ☐ **Axle-to-chassis fastener torque**
  2010–2011 · NHTSA 11V-145
- ☐ **Power-steering line rubs transmission cooler tube**
  2012–2013 · NHTSA 13V-234
- ☐ **Heated mirror connector short**
  2011–2013 · NHTSA 14V-631
- ☐ **Front impact sensor wiring**
  2016–2017 · NHTSA 16V-734

## IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Real Rubicon**
  Dana 44 axles front and rear with Tru-Lok electronic lockers, Rock-Trac transfer case with 4:1 low range, 4.10 gears and an electronic sway-bar disconnect switch. Sport and Sahara trucks have Command-Trac with 2.72:1 low range.
- ☐ **Axles by trim**
  Sport (X) and Sahara have a Dana 30 front and a Dana 44 rear; Quadratec says fewer than a thousand early 2007s got a Dana 35 rear instead. Rubicon has Dana 44s at both ends. A rear locker was optional on X and Sahara for 2007, then on select X models for 2008–2009.
- ☐ **Engine and year**
  2007–2011 trucks have the 3.8 EGH V6 (4-speed 42RLE auto or 6-speed manual). 2012–2018 trucks have the 3.6 Pentastar (5-speed W5A580 auto or 6-speed manual). 2011 got the new interior a year before the new engine.
- ☐ **Four-door vs TJ Unlimited**
  The JK Unlimited's wheelbase grew by 20.6 in to 116 in, a true four-door rather than the stretched two-door TJ Unlimited. Two-wheel-drive Unlimiteds (X and Sahara) were sold only through 2010.
- ☐ **Hemi swaps and AEV builds**
  Plenty of Unlimiteds carry 5.7 or 6.4 Hemi swaps or AEV conversions (AEV's 'Brute' double-cab pickup ran about four years). Ask for the build paperwork and an emissions-compliance record for your state.
- ☐ **Postal right-hand drive**
  From 2009 the factory right-hand-drive Wrangler was an Unlimited. These have their own RHD-only recalls.

## NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/jk-unlimited/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks